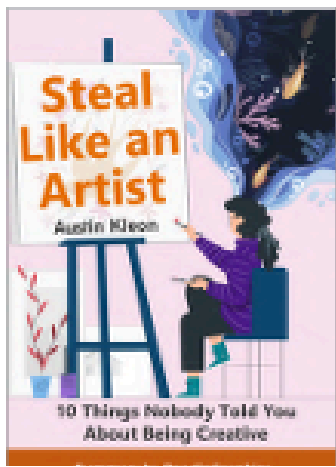




STEAL LIKE AN ARTIST

10 Things Nobody Told You About Being Creative

Austin Kleon



The Big “So What”

How can you ignite your creativity and make your ideas truly shine? This book presents transformative insights to shift your mindset, remix ideas into innovative solutions, discover your authentic voice, and unlock your full creative potential. Whether you're an artist, entrepreneur, or someone seeking fresh inspiration, this book empowers you to thrive with meaningful and authentic creations.



Introduction

✚ In this book, artist and writer Austin Kleon redefines creativity by showing that all great ideas are built upon the foundations of what came before. Creativity isn't about conjuring something from thin air. It's the deliberate process of borrowing ideas, reimagining them, and building upon them to create something truly unique.

💡 Kleon's own work is inspired by icons like Pablo Picasso and T.S. Eliot, who openly embraced the idea of creative borrowing. Kleon combines their wisdom with his practical experiences to present 10 key ideas that empower readers to curate their influences, find their voice, and produce work that feels fresh and authentic.

KEY QUOTES

"The only art I'll ever study is stuff that I can steal from."
—David Bowie

*"What is originality?
Undetected plagiarism."*
—William Ralph Inge

10 Ideas to Unleash Your Creative Potential



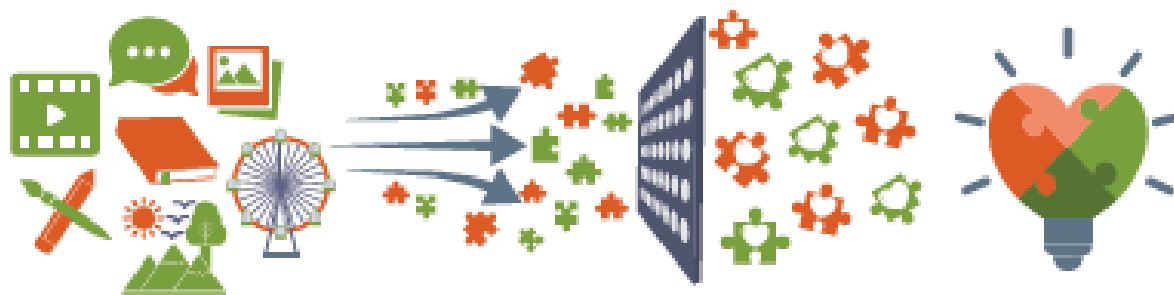
KEY QUOTES



10 Big Ideas to Unleash Your Untapped Creative Potential



1. Curate, then Create



There's no such thing as a completely "original" idea; every new concept is built on something that already exists. Creativity is about blending existing elements in refreshing or unexpected ways.

- Consider *genetics*: You inherit genes and traits from both your parents, yet you are different from them due to your unique life experiences. Likewise, creativity is about combining inherited ideas with your own perspective to produce something distinctive.



Not all ideas are worth borrowing. True creators master the art of selective stealing.

- Unlike hoarders, who collect indiscriminately and create clutter, real artists are *discerning collectors*. They selectively gather ideas that they love and resonate deeply with, then combine them to create something unique, meaningful, and authentic.

"All creative work builds on what came before. Nothing is completely original."

"Every new idea is just a mashup or a remix of one or more previous ideas."

"Hoarders collect indiscriminately, artists collect selectively. They only collect things that they really love."

- When curating your influences, don't worry about what's "good" or "bad." Just focus on inspires you and feels worth stealing.

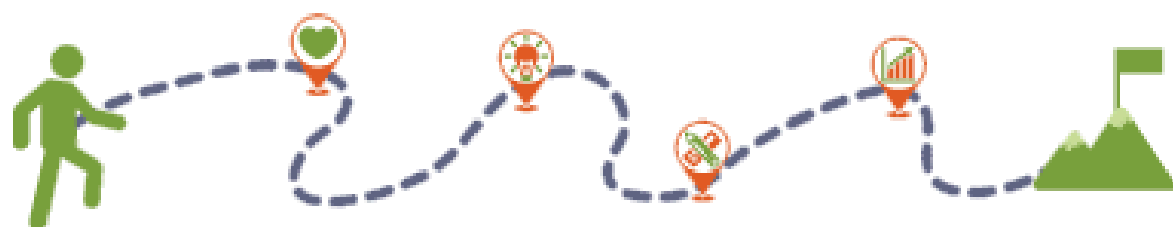


Here are several practical tips for curating inspiration:

- We become the average of the 5 people we spend the most time with. So, surround yourself with people, ideas, and objects that uplift and inspire you.
- Carry a digital or analog notebook with you, and jot down good ideas as you encounter them. Great ideas can come from anywhere—films, books, music, paintings, architectures, nature, or daily conversations. Gather these ideas to create your personal scrapbook or swipe file of good ideas and inspirations.
- Adopt an open, learning mindset. Read widely, question deeply, and explore the world with wonder and curiosity.
- Use the internet to search for virtually any answer or solution.
- Form your "creative lineage" by studying the work of artists, writers, and creators you admire. Look for themes or patterns to understand what makes their work interesting and unique.
 - (i) Start with a role model you truly respect. Learn everything you can about them.
 - (ii) Identify 3 people they admired and learn about them too.
 - (iii) Keep expanding your "family tree" of creative lineage.
 - (iv) When you're ready, start your own branch in that tree, by blending their influences into your unique perspective. Return frequently to this lineage as a source of support and inspiration for your work.



2. Start Before You're Ready



Start creating now. Don't wait the perfect opportunity or until you feel "ready".

KEY QUOTES

"You're only going to be as good as the stuff you surround yourself with."

"Steal from anywhere that resonates with inspiration or fuels your imagination... Select only things to steal from that speak directly to your soul. If you do this, your work (and theft) will be authentic."
—Jim Jarmusch

"Don't worry about doing research. Just search."

"It is better to take what does not belong to you than to let it lie around neglected."
—Mark Twain

"In my experience, it's in the act of making things and doing our work that we figure out who we are."

KEY QUOTES

"You're ready. Start making stuff."

"Your style will emerge over time as you create and develop your skills."

"You have to dress for the job you want, not the job you have, and you have to start doing the work you want to be doing."

"All the world's a stage. Creative work is a kind of theater. The stage is your studio, your desk, or your workstation."

"If you have one person you're influenced by, everyone will say you're the next whoever. But if you rip off a hundred people, everyone will say you're so original!"
— Gary Panter

"If you just mimic the surface of somebody's work without understanding where they are coming from, your work will never be anything more than a knockoff."

- Creativity flourishes through action, not perfection. When you first start to create something, you'll have no idea what you are doing. It is by doing that you develop your skills and discover your style.
- It is normal to feel insecure or like a fraud. This is known as the imposter syndrome, where you feel like a phony who's just winging it. Just push through it by taking action regardless.

 Fake it until you make it. Show up consistently and keep doing the work, even if it feels messy or imperfect.

- Keep creating until you craft something meaningful. Keep rehearsing at being the person you aspire to be. Eventually, your actions and reality will align with your vision.
- Everything we know is learned from someone else. Before you can be a master of your craft, you must first be an apprentice who studies and emulates others.

 Know the difference between good theft (copying) vs bad theft (plagiarism).

- Good theft is about reverse-engineering something to uncover how it works. It involves deeply analyzing others' work and successes, then adapting and reshaping the ideas to create something new, while acknowledging and giving credit to those sources.
- Bad theft is about claiming others' work as your own, such as superficially mimicking someone's work, undermining its originality, and misrepresenting it as your creation.

 There are 2 aspects to copying:

- Who to copy: Look to the role models, thinkers, and creators you deeply admire. Learn from multiple sources and integrate their influences to create something different.
- What to copy: Go beyond surface-level mimicry. Instead, study the thought processes and worldview behind the work. Seek to understand the principles that shape their style or approach, so you can integrate these insights into your own work.

 Find your unique voice by studying the differences between your heroes' work and yours.

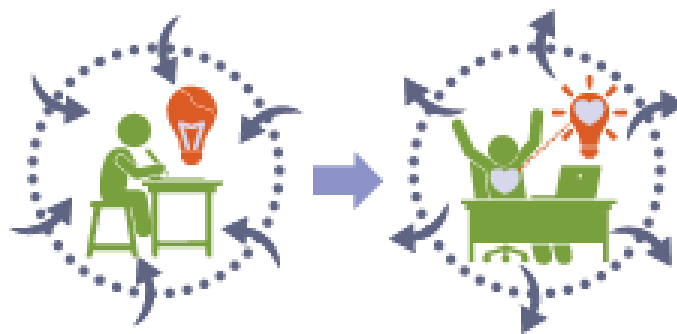
- No matter how hard you try, you can never replicate your heroes' work perfectly—and that's a good thing. Pay attention to the gaps between their work and yours, then focus on amplifying those differences to nurture your unique style.
- Build on the foundation provided by your heroes, to create something that's undeniably yours.



3. Create What You Wish Existed



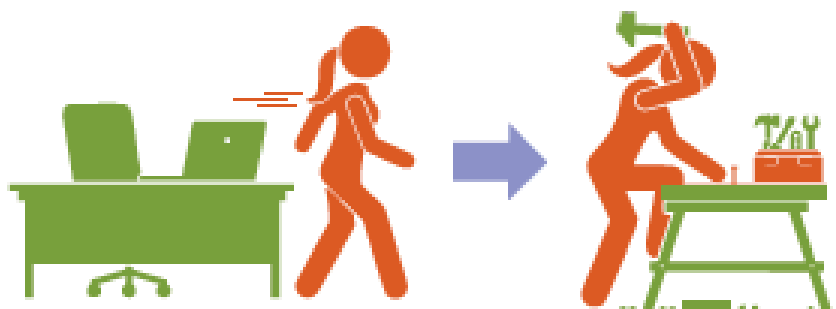
Don't create what you think you *should* create. Instead, focus on what you love and what excites or inspires you. Create the things you wish existed in the world.



- Instead of writing what you know, channel your passions and desires into writing what you love and care about. This ensures your work feels authentic and meaningful.
- Ask yourself: What would you have loved your heroes to create—either on their own or as part of a collaboration? Then, go make them yourself.
- If you feel frustrated by the gaps in an area or the lack of options, fill that void with your own voice or creation. This is how you contribute your unique skills and perspective to create something both meaningful and impactful.



4. Engage Your Body & Senses



KEY QUOTES

"The best advice is not to write what you know, it's to write what you like. Write the kind of story you like best—write the story you want to read."

"Draw the art you want to see, start the business you want to run, play the music you want to hear, write the books you want to read, build the products you want to use—do the work you want to see done."



Creativity involves the entire body, not just the mind. Great artists, musicians, and leaders engage their entire bodies when they create, perform, or inspire.

- Movement stimulates your senses and sparks creativity. Sitting still at a computer for hours isn't the ideal way to generate ideas. Instead, step away from the screen occasionally.
- To get your creative juices flowing, use your hands to make or do something tangible. Move sticky notes around, play an instrument, sketch on paper, or work with clay. The physical act of creating activates your mind-body connection, engages your senses, and helps ideas to flow more naturally.

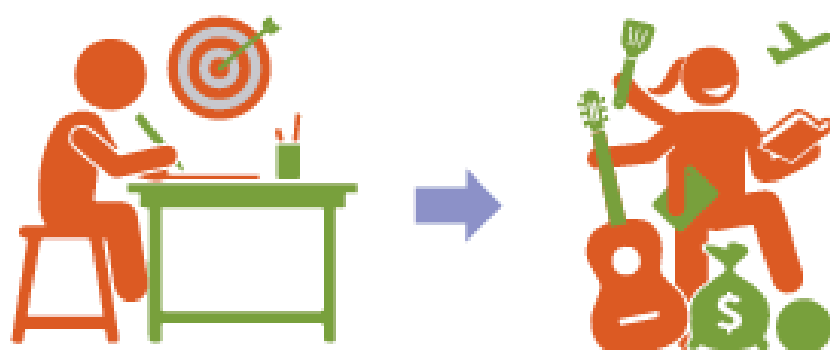


Switch between digital and analog workspaces.

- Kleon suggests maintaining 2 workstations:
 - (i) An *analog workspace* (e.g. pen, paper, and sticky notes); and
 - (ii) A *digital workspace* (e.g. your computer).
- Toggle between the two to harness the strengths of each. For example:
 - You could print your work, pin up ideas on a wall, or draft concepts on paper. Then, move to your digital tools to refine and execute those ideas.
 - Use this back-and-forth rhythm to generate ideas offline and polish/publish them online, blending tactile creativity with the efficiency of digital tools.



5. Nurture Your Creative Outlets



KEY QUOTES

"Sitting in front of a computer all day is killing you, and killing your work. We need to move, to feel like we're making something with our bodies, not just our heads."

"Your hands are the original digital devices. Use them."

"Our nerves aren't a one-way street—our bodies can tell our brains as much as our brains tell our bodies."



Explore multiple interests: Hobbies and side projects can offer a valuable outlet for creativity, leading to new ideas and unexpected opportunities.

- Allow yourself to work on side projects and fun hobbies outside your main responsibilities. These can spark fresh perspectives, and help you to develop new skills and inspiration from diverse fields that you wouldn't normally dive into.
- Avoid discarding hobbies or interests you enjoy, just to force yourself to focus on one thing.
 - These passions are part of who you are. They can also lead to creative breakthroughs by combining diverse skills or ideas.
 - If you feel incomplete after letting go of something—be it music, art, or social groups—make sure you bring them back into your life.
- Dabble in new ideas, activities, or hobbies, such as gardening, photography, or sketching. It's ok to mess around and do things just for fun—just go with the flow and see where your curiosity takes you.



Embrace boredom and productive procrastination: Give yourself time to daydream, go for a walk, or engage in mundane tasks like ironing or washing dishes.

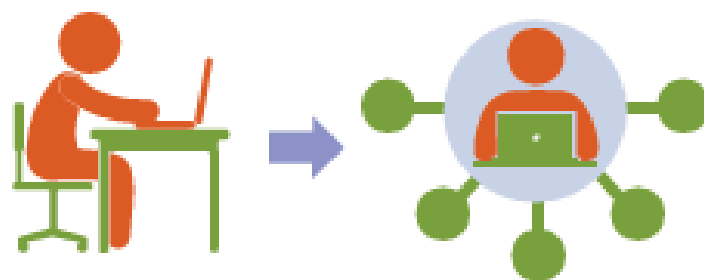
- Some of Kleon's best ideas surface during moments of quiet or boredom, when the mind is able to wander.



6. Create Great Work, then Share With Others



Use this straightforward yet powerful formula for success: do good work and share it with others.



- Step 1: Get good first. Consistency is key. Keep showing up daily to create, experiment, and hone your skills. You'll be lousy at first, but that's normal since progress comes through practice.

KEY QUOTES

"The work you do while you procrastinate is probably the work you should be doing for the rest of your life."

—Jessica Hische

"Take time to mess around. Get lost. Wander. You never know where it's going to lead you."

"It's the side projects that really take off...Stuff that's just play. That's actually the good stuff. That's when the magic happens."

"Avoiding work is the way to focus my mind."

— Maira Kalman

"Creative people need time to just sit around and do nothing."

KEY QUOTES

"Enjoy your obscurity while it lasts. Use it."

"You don't put yourself online only because you have something to say—you can put yourself online to find something to say."

"People love it when you give your secrets away, and sometimes, if you're smart about it, they'll reward you by buying the things you're selling. When you open up your process and invite people in, you learn."

"You can share your dots without connecting them... You have control over what you share and how much you reveal."

*"Distance and difference are the secret tonic of creativity. When we get home, home is still the same. But something in our mind has been changed, and that changes everything."
—Jonah Lehrer*

- Enjoy the initial freedom of obscurity. With no one watching, you can explore, fail, and try again without pressure.
- Explore topics or ideas that fascinate you, especially those that others aren't paying attention to. Let your curiosity and unique interests guide you and set you apart.
- Step 2: Share your work: Share your passion, discoveries, and insights with others who share similar interests.
 - In today's digital age, it's easier than ever to share your work online. Sharing opens doors to learning, growth, and collaboration. It may even connect you with future customers.
 - Treat this as a discovery process. Don't just share finished work—also show behind-the-scenes progress, test new ideas and invite feedback.

 Tips for sharing your work: You don't have to give away everything you know in order to build a community, gain feedback, or increase visibility/impact. You can:

- Give small glimpses: Share snippets of your work, parts of your process, or helpful insights and resources you've found valuable.
- Show your journey: Take your audience behind the scenes to help them understand your work and creative process.
- Retain some secrets: You don't have to reveal everything. For instance, you can share core elements of your work without connecting all the dots to reveal the full picture or secret.

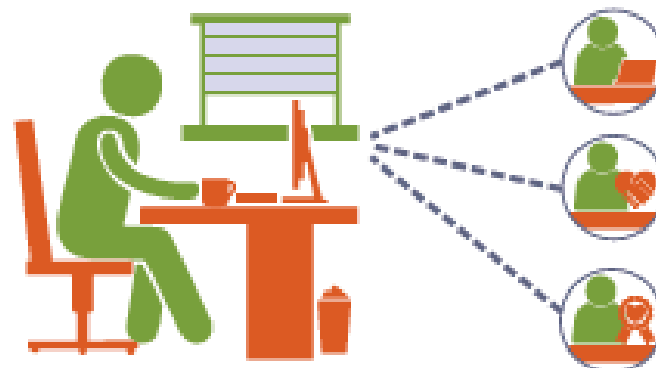


7. Connect and Create Anywhere



Today, physical location is no longer a constraint for creative work.

- The internet allows you to connect globally with people who share your interests. It's easier than



ever to exchange ideas, collaborate on projects, and network with diverse, like-minded individuals through online communities or events.

- Choose an environment that suits your creative needs, whether it's working from home, a café, or a remote destination.



To create a conducive environment for creative work:

- Embrace solitude: Give yourself mental space to think deeply, free from distractions and external noise.
 - Dedicate a quiet workspace and set regular time blocks for interruption-free work.
 - Surround yourself with inspiring materials like books, images or art, while minimizing distractions.
- Use "temporary captivity": Restrict yourself to specific environments or situations that facilitate focus, such as a quiet room or a location without Wi-Fi.
 - Use waiting time—like commuting or standing in line—to brainstorm or observe the world for inspiration. Always carry a notebook to jot down ideas.



Kleon recommends leaving home at least once, to immerse yourself in a new environment and step outside your comfort zone.

- Explore different cultures, practices, and beliefs to stimulate your mind.
- Make yourself at home in a location where you thrive physically, mentally, and emotionally—in terms of surroundings, food, people, and weather that support your creativity.

KEY QUOTES

"All you need is a little space and a little time—a place to work, and some time to do it; a little self-imposed solitude and temporary captivity."

"When you can do it, you have to leave home. You can always come back, but you have to leave at least once."

"You have to find a place that feeds you—creatively, socially, spiritually, and literally."

"Travel makes the world look new, and when the world looks new, our brains work harder."



8. Make Friends, Not Enemies





In today's interconnected world, you should assume that everything you say or do—good or bad—can be seen by others. Kleon's advice is simple: be nice. Say good things about people you like, and ignore your enemies.

- Surround yourself with talented, inspiring people:
 - Follow and connect with people who are *smarter and more talented than you*, and whose work genuinely inspires you. Pay attention to what they do, who they connect with, and what they talk about.
 - *Publicly share your appreciation* for their work. Link to their website, solve a problem they're facing, answer a question they posed, or even create something inspired by them. Do this selflessly, without expecting anything in return. Treat any response you get as a bonus, not your main goal.
- Build meaningful connections with kindness: Where possible, compliment others, offer help/support, and contribute positively to your communities.
- Avoid arguments or negativity online. If you encounter something that upsets you, don't waste time/energy complaining or arguing about it online. Channel your anger and frustrations into your creative work.



Creativity requires a mix of curiosity, persistence, and humility. Focus on self-encouragement, not external validation, and be willing to get uncomfortable or even look foolish.

- Don't depend on external validation to motivate yourself. Not everyone will understand or value your work, and recognition (if any) may come much later, sometimes even after your death.
- Ignore criticisms from haters and naysayers, trust your journey, and immerse yourself in your work instead.
- Intentionally celebrate the positives. Keep a "praise file" of positive feedback, kind words, and compliments from your fans or community. During tough times, revisit these to remind yourself of your impact and keep going.

KEY QUOTES

"There's only one rule I know of: You've got to be kind."
—Kurt Vonnegut

"The best way to vanquish your enemies on the Internet? Ignore them. The best way to make friends on the Internet? Say nice things about them."

"If you ever find that you're the most talented person in the room, you need to find another room."

"Go on, get angry. But keep your mouth shut and go do your work."

"The best way to get approval is to not need it."
— Hugh MacLeod

"Get comfortable with being misunderstood, disparaged, or ignored—the trick is to be too busy doing your work to care."



9. Create Structure for Creative Freedom



When you think of a creative genius, do you think of a bohemian-style, free-spirited individual surrounded by adventure and indulgence? That's a myth. Creative work requires discipline, consistency, and balance.



- Creative success often comes from a structured, "boring" life with consistent routines, adequate rest, and self-care. Such a balanced lifestyle provides the required energy and focus for your creative goals.



Build a strong, stable foundation:

- Manage your finances wisely. Live within your means and stay out of debt to reduce financial strain.
- Keep your day job while you pursue your creative passions.
 - This (i) provides financial security, (ii) adds structure to your day and (iii) creates opportunities to learn from others.
 - Choose a job that pays the bills, doesn't drain your energy, and leaves you with enough time for your creative pursuits.



Devote consistent creative time to sustain the momentum.

- Work out how much time you can free up for creative work, create a routine, and stick to it. It's hard to regain momentum once it's broken.
- Try Jerry Seinfeld's calendar method to sustain motivation. Break your annual goal into daily chunks, then mark a tick on our calendar for each day you complete your work. As the chain of ticks grows, you will feel more motivated to keep going and maintain the momentum.
- Keep a simple logbook to track your journey and what you accomplish each day. Record key activities, creative work, or even small highlights (e.g. a good meal or a meaningful interaction). This reinforces progress and helps you reflect on your growth.

KEY QUOTES

"Be regular and orderly in your life, so that you may be violent and original in your work."

—Gustave Flaubert

"It takes a lot of energy to be creative. You don't have that energy if you waste it on other stuff."

"Freedom from financial stress also means freedom in your art."

"The art of holding on to money is all about saying no to consumer culture."

"Inertia is the death of creativity. You have to stay in the groove."

"Get a calendar. Fill the boxes. Don't break the chain."

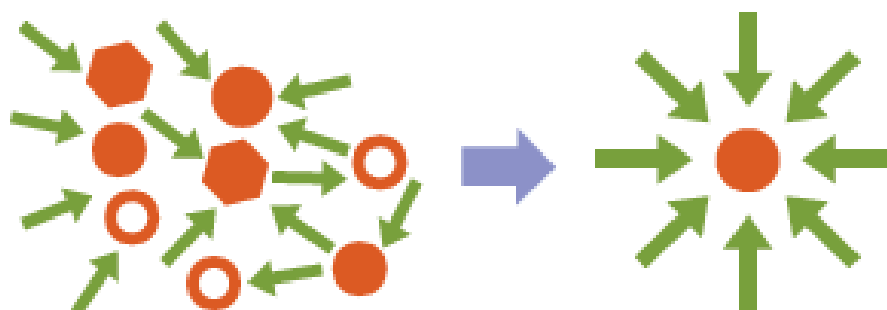
"Do the work every day, no matter what. No holidays, no sick days. Don't stop."



Find the right partners who support your creative goals and helps you stay grounded and focused. This applies not just in marriage, but also in business and friendship.



10. Simplify to Amplify



Creativity isn't about constantly adding more—it's often about removing what's unnecessary to reveal what truly matters.

- Too many choices or elements can overwhelm and paralyze. By stripping away the non-essentials, you can focus on the core of your work, and create something that's more meaningful and impactful.
- In creative work, what you choose to leave out can be as interesting and valuable as what you choose to include. Thoughtful subtraction can make your work cleaner, more focused, and more compelling.



Try adding constraints to overcome creative blocks. Simplify and do more with less.

- See constraints not as limitations, but tools to spark creativity and resourcefulness. For instance, challenge yourself to:
 - Complete a task within a strict time frame (e.g. 1 hour);
 - Create something with only one color or material; or
 - Film a project entirely with your phone.
- Instead of waiting for perfect conditions or ideal resources, work with what you have. Start creating and moving forward.

KEY QUOTES

"The small details will help you remember the big details."

"Relationships are hard enough, but it takes a real champion of a person to be married to someone who's obsessed with a creative pursuit."

"Nothing is more paralyzing than the idea of limitless possibilities. The idea that you can do anything is absolutely terrifying."

"In the end, creativity isn't just the things we choose to put in, it's the things we choose to leave out."

"When it comes to creative work, limitations mean freedom."

"In this age of information abundance and overload, those who get ahead will be the folks who figure out what to leave out, so they can concentrate on what's really important to them."